

Psalms as Aiming Tools — and Paul on the Misaimed Heart

The Thesis

You have an appetite for something complete. Something that does not need you, that is not lacking, that could look at you and settle the question of whether you are real. That appetite is standard equipment. It is the vertical thing.

It has no off switch. If the thing it was built for is unavailable, or unrecognized, it does not shut down and wait. It goes sideways. It takes the nearest available human and installs them in the slot. Girard calls this **deviated transcendency**. Vertical desire aimed horizontally.

The problem this creates is not that you want too much. It is that you cannot aim. And you cannot aim by willpower, because desire is never direct. You have never once wanted anything by yourself. It is always copied, always through someone. So "want less" is not on the menu and neither is "redirect by force." The only move that has ever existed is changing who you copy.

The claim of this document: the psalms are aiming tools. They are a technology for addressing God built by and for people who could not aim. You do not have to generate the feeling. You do not have to find the words or reach the right state. You say the words and the words do the aiming.

That is what a liturgy is. Not a performance of piety. A device for addressing God on the days you have nothing to send.

This problem is not modern. The tool is three thousand years old and it was built because the problem was already old.

STAGE ONE — Read These Cold

Do not read Stage Two first. Read these with nothing next to them. Get confused. The confusion is the work.

Read each one and write in the gutter only this: *who is being spoken to, and what does the speaker want*. Nothing else. Do not resolve anything.

- **Psalm 73** — read this one twice
- **Psalm 51**
- **Psalm 42 and 43** (one psalm, read as one)
- **Psalm 88**
- **Psalm 115**
- **Psalm 13**
- **Psalm 63**
- **Psalm 131**

Sit with the confusion for at least one session before Stage Two. If you go straight to the frame you will learn the frame and not the psalms.

STAGE TWO — What an Aiming Tool Is

The mechanism is visible in Psalm 42

"Why, my soul, are you downcast? Why so disturbed within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise him, my Savior and my God."
(42:5)

Notice what is happening grammatically. The psalmist is not talking to God here. He is talking **to himself**, and he is telling himself where to point. That is the tool operating in the open. It is self-address that redirects the address.

He does not report that he feels hope. He commands himself toward it. The feeling is not the input.

Psalm 73 is the whole problem and the whole answer in one psalm

This is the spine text. Asaph names mimetic envy in the second verse and does not pretend otherwise:

"But as for me, my feet had almost slipped; I had nearly lost my foothold. For I envied the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked." (73:2-3)

The middle of the psalm is a man cataloguing other people's lives and measuring his own against them. That is the horizontal. That is the triangle running at full speed.

Then the hinge:

"till I entered the sanctuary of God; then I understood their final destiny." (73:17)

Not "till I reasoned it out." Not "till I felt better." **Till I entered.** The change of position preceded the change of understanding. He went somewhere and the aim corrected.

And then the verse that answers deviated transcendence directly:

"Whom have I in heaven but you? And earth has nothing I desire besides you." (73:25)

That is not a man with less desire. That is a man with the same appetite and a corrected address.

Psalm 115:8 is the law of the model

"Those who make them will be like them, and so will all who trust in them."

You become what you worship. This is mimetic transformation stated as law. If your model is a dead thing you become dead. The verse is about idols but the mechanism is general and it is the reason the choice of model is the only choice that matters.

Psalm 88 exists so you cannot cheat

"You have taken from me friend and neighbor — darkness is my closest friend." (88:18)

It ends there. No resolution, no turn, no comfort. It is in the book anyway.

This is why the tool works. If every psalm resolved, then the psalms would be a performance requirement and you would fail them on your worst nights. Psalm 88 is proof that the address is valid even when nothing improves. The aiming does not depend on the outcome.

Psalm 51:17 and the line you got wrong

"My sacrifice, O God, is a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart you, God, will not despise."

The broken heart is the offering. It is the one thing never turned away. It does not need to be fixed first in order to be brought.

(Compare your own 4am text, where you wrote "that contrite heart that broken spirit that has no one to go to." You quoted the psalm accurately for six lines and the wording changed exactly here. The one verse that says your broken heart has somewhere to go came out as a heart with nowhere. Worth sitting with why that word moved. Not as a verdict, just as something the psalm hands back to you.)

STAGE THREE — Cross-Reference Prompts

Do not read the answers below. **Find these yourself and write them into the gutter of Stage One.**

1. Psalm 73:25 says earth has nothing he desires besides God. Find the verse in Psalm 16 that says the same thing in four words. Write it next to 73:25.
2. Psalm 115:8 says you become what you trust. Find the near-duplicate of this verse in Psalm 135. Ask why it is said twice.

3. Psalm 42 addresses the soul directly. Find every other place in the Psalter where the psalmist gives his own soul an order. Start with Psalm 103 and Psalm 116.
 4. Psalm 27:4 says "one thing." Psalm 73:25 says "nothing besides." Are these the same claim? Write your answer before you read anyone else's.
 5. Psalm 63:1 uses thirst. Find where Jesus uses thirst in the same sense. Then find where he uses it on the cross. Are these the same use?
 6. Psalm 115:8 says you become what you trust. Find the verse in 2 Corinthians 3 that says the same thing about looking at Christ. Write it directly underneath 115:8 in the gutter. They are the same law pointed in opposite directions.
 7. Exodus 33:20 says no one can see God's face and live. Numbers 12:8 says God spoke to Moses face to face. Both are true and both are in the Torah. Do not resolve this yet. Write both down and leave the contradiction standing.
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STAGE FOUR — Paul on This Exact Problem

Paul names this mechanism repeatedly and with more precision than he is usually given credit for. These are the chapters.

1. Romans 1:21-25 — the exchange

The single closest text. This is deviated transcendence described in the first century.

"and exchanged the glory of the immortal God for images made to look like a mortal human being and birds and animals and reptiles."
(1:23)

"They exchanged the truth about God for a lie, and worshiped and served created things rather than the Creator." (1:25)

Exchanged. The verb carries the passage. Note that Paul does not say they stopped worshipping. He says the worship got **redirected**. The appetite is intact. The address is wrong. That is the entire concept, and

Girard did not invent it.

Ask in the gutter: why is the sequence "worshiped AND served"? What does the second verb add?

2. Romans 7:14-25 into 8:1 — the circle and the exit

Your circle, in Paul's mouth:

"I do not understand what I do. For what I want to do I do not do, but what I hate I do." (7:15)

"What a wretched man I am! Who will rescue me from this body that is subject to death?" (7:24)

That is "I keep going in the same circle over and over" and "I am a piece of shit of a person who deserves nothing," written two thousand years earlier by the most competent man in the New Testament.

And then, without a chapter break in the original:

"Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus." (8:1)

The verdict is voided. Note the structure: Paul does not answer the circle by escaping the circle. He answers it by removing the sentence attached to it.

This is the most important passage in the document. Read 7:14 through 8:4 as one continuous text with no chapter number in between. The chapter division is doing damage here.

3. Galatians 1:10 — the address

"Am I now trying to win the approval of human beings, or of God? Or am I trying to please people? If I were still trying to please people, I would not be a servant of Christ."

Paul names the two possible addressees and says you get one. This is the Aya verse. The question is never how much you want. It is who the wanting is addressed to.

4. Philippians 3:4-14 — ambition, re-addressed

Paul lists his CV. Circumcised on the eighth day, tribe of Benjamin, Pharisee, faultless as to the law. A real résumé, and he was not lying about any of it.

"But whatever were gains to me I now consider loss for the sake of Christ." (3:7)

He does not say the achievements were fake. He says the **ledger** they were entered in was the wrong ledger. Every line was addressed to someone. He changed the recipient and the whole page re-valued.

Compare with your own: "the person I want to be that isn't sad because of her is a person who accomplishes things." Same structure. Achievement as a letter. Ask whether Paul's move is available to you now or whether it rests on something not yet in place. Write your honest answer.

5. 2 Corinthians 10:12 — comparison refused

"We do not dare to classify or compare ourselves with some who commend themselves. When they measure themselves by themselves and compare themselves with themselves, they are not wise."

Mimetic comparison, named and declined. Note the strange doubled phrasing: *themselves by themselves, themselves with themselves*. Paul is describing a closed loop with no exterior. Ask why he repeats it rather than saying it once.

6. Colossians 3:1-5 — the vertical, stated as a direction

"Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things." (3:2)

Above and earthly. Vertical and horizontal, in the plainest terms available.

Then, four verses later, the definition that does the work:

"...greed, which is idolatry." (3:5)

Greed is idolatry. Not "greed is like idolatry," not "greed leads to idolatry." Misdirected wanting *is* worship pointed wrong. Paul collapses the two categories into one. This verse is the hinge of the whole document.

7. Ephesians 4:22-24 — deceitful desires

"You were taught, with regard to your former way of life, to put off your old self, which is being corrupted by its deceitful desires."
(4:22)

Deceitful desires. Deceit and desire. Girard's title is sitting in this verse. The claim is that desire lies about its own object, which is exactly the claim of the triangle.

8. 1 Corinthians 11:1 — the chain

"Follow my example, as I follow the example of Christ."

The shortest and most structurally loaded verse here. Paul offers himself as a model **and in the same breath points past himself**. He refuses to terminate the chain in his own person.

That is the anti-Aya move, and it is the only known way to be someone's model without becoming their rival: do not be the destination.

9. Philippians 2:5-11 — the model who does not grasp

"In your relationships with one another, have the same mindset as Christ Jesus: Who, being in very nature God, did not consider equality with God something to be used to his own advantage." (2:5-6)

The NIV footnote gives the older rendering: *something to be grasped*. Grasping is the mimetic move. This is the one figure in the story who declines it, which is why imitating him does not produce collision. His own desire is not pointed at himself, so he passes you through.

10. Galatians 5:15 and 5:26 — the doubles

"If you bite and devour each other, watch out or you will be destroyed by each other." (5:15)

"Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying each other." (5:26)

Reciprocal violence and reciprocal envy, both stated as **mutual**. Not "do not envy them." *Each other*. Paul sees the loop, not the individual sin.

11. Romans 12:2 — the pattern

"Do not conform to the pattern of this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind."

Conform is a shaping word. You are molded by what surrounds you, by default, without deciding to be. Note your own sentence: "I keep on seeing that there is a pattern in my behaviour." Same word, and Paul's diagnosis is that the pattern is not originally yours.

12. Romans 5:3-5 — shame voided

"And hope does not put us to shame, because God's love has been poured out into our hearts through the Holy Spirit, who has been given to us." (5:5)

Shame is the currency of the triangle. It is what you pay when the mediator withholds. This verse removes the currency from circulation.

13. The mirror chain — Psalm 115:8, 2 Corinthians 3:18, 1 Corinthians 13:12

This is the capstone. It runs Psalm 115:8 forward into Paul and closes the document.

First, a correction to make before you read further. Paul's mirror is not a modern mirror. There was no silvered glass in the first century. A mirror was a sheet of polished bronze, and Corinth was known for manufacturing

them, so his readers owned these objects. A bronze mirror gives a **dim, warped, murky image**. Not a crisp copy of your face.

And the NIV smooths out the decisive phrase. The Greek of 13:12 reads *di' esoptrou en ainigmati*: **through** a mirror, **in a riddle**. *Ainigma*. Enigma. The ESV keeps it: "we see in a mirror dimly."

So Paul's contrast is **not** self versus other. It is **indirect and murky** versus **direct and clear**. The mirror is not a wall standing between you and God. It is a bad instrument you are currently seeing him *through*. You are already looking at the right thing. Badly.

Do not build anything on the modern reading. The verse does not say "you only ever see yourself."

The chain:

"Those who make them will be like them, and so will all who trust in them." (Psalm 115:8)

You become what you look at. The law of the model, stated in the Psalter. Look at a dead thing, become dead.

"And we all, who with unveiled faces contemplate the Lord's glory, are being transformed into his image with ever-increasing glory, which comes from the Lord, who is the Spirit." (2 Corinthians 3:18)

The same law, running the right direction. And the Greek verb here is *katoptrizomenoi*, built on *katoptron*, mirror. The NIV footnote gives the alternative rendering: *reflect*. The word carries both beholding-as-in-a-mirror and reflecting-as-a-mirror, and the ambiguity is the point. You look at him, and in looking you are made into a thing that shows him. The mirror stops being what you look *through* and becomes what you *are*.

Psalm 115:8 is the curse version. 2 Corinthians 3:18 is the blessing version. Identical mechanism.

"For now we see only a reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known." (1 Corinthians 13:12)

Read 13:8-12 as one unit. Paul has just said we know **in part**, and that "when completeness comes, what is in part disappears" (13:9-10), and then the childhood analogy in 13:11. The mirror is the *in part*. It is not a sin. It is the current instrument, correct for now, incomplete by design.

Note the asymmetry, which is the whole payload: **your** seeing is what is deferred. The being-known is not. "Even as I am fully known." Present tense. His view of you was never through the bronze.

Face of whom, and why the phrase matters:

"With him I speak face to face, clearly and not in riddles; he sees the form of the LORD." (Numbers 12:8)

God, defending Moses. Same two ideas, same pairing: face to face, and not in riddles. Paul is reaching for the most privileged encounter in the Hebrew Bible, the thing that made Moses Moses, and promising it to everyone.

Which is enormous, because the standing rule is:

"But," he said, "you cannot see my face, for no one may see me and live." (Exodus 33:20)

And the Bible closes on:

"They will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads."
(Revelation 22:4)

Exodus 33:20 to Revelation 22:4 is the arc of the whole book, and 1 Corinthians 13:12 is standing in the middle of it telling you which end you are at.

On the silversmith illustration — read this before using it

The image: a silversmith holds the metal in the fire and knows the refining is finished when he can see his own face reflected in it. We are perfected when he can see his image in us.

It is a good image and it belongs in the chain, because polished metal is a mirror. Refining and reflecting are the same process. That is exactly 2 Corinthians 3:18.

But you must know what it is. The detail about the silversmith seeing his face is a **devotional illustration, not scripture**. It is a preacher's story, widely told, attached to Malachi 3:3. It is not in the text of Malachi or anywhere else. If you say it on camera as though it were the Bible, you will be corrected, and correctly.

What the text actually says:

"For he will be like a refiner's fire or a launderer's soap. He will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver; he will purify the Levites and refine them like gold and silver." (Malachi 3:2-3)

He sits. He refines. He purifies. That is all Malachi says. The *sitting* is doing real work, the patience of it, but there is no face in the silver.

Supporting crucible texts, all genuine:

"The crucible for silver and the furnace for gold, but the LORD tests the heart." (Proverbs 17:3)

"And the words of the LORD are flawless, like silver purified in a crucible, like gold refined seven times." (Psalm 12:6)

"See, I have refined you, though not as silver; I have tested you in the furnace of affliction." (Isaiah 48:10)

The honest way to use it: tell the silversmith story and label it as an illustration, then land on 2 Corinthians 3:18 as the actual claim. The illustration is a preacher's picture. The verse is the argument. The verse is also stronger, because it says something the story does not: that the reflecting is not the end of the process but the *means* of it. You are not polished so that he can admire himself in you. You are transformed by *looking at him*. The looking is the refining.

Gutter question: is the illustration doing work the verse cannot do, or is it doing work the verse does better? If the second, cut it.

STAGE FIVE — Questions You Answer, Not Me

Write your answers in the gutter. Date them. Answer again on the next pass and do not look at the old answer first.

1. Psalm 73:17 says the understanding came after *entering the sanctuary*. If you have no sanctuary to enter, what is the honest equivalent? Is there one, or is the absence itself worth naming rather than filling?
 2. Romans 7 and Psalm 88 both refuse to resolve. Why are both in the canon? What would be lost if either resolved?
 3. Colossians 3:5 says greed is idolatry. Run it backwards. If misdirected desire is idolatry, then is idolatry just misdirected desire, or is that reversal illegitimate? Defend your answer.
 4. 1 Corinthians 11:1 has Paul refusing to be the destination. Name every person in your own life you have made a destination. Do not write the list here. Just count them.
 5. Psalm 51 was written by a man who had done something genuinely monstrous, not by a man who felt bad about himself. Does that change how the psalm works as a tool for you? Repentance and self-hatred can borrow the same words. Which of the two is the psalm actually asking for.
 6. If the psalms aim, and you cannot feel the aiming, on what grounds would you know it was working? Answer before you decide whether it is working.
 7. 1 Corinthians 13:12 says your seeing is partial but that you are *already* fully known. Which half of that sentence do you actually believe? Answer honestly, then ask what it would change if you believed the other half.
 8. You reach for diagrams to describe everything, more readily than for pictures or rooms or faces. A diagram is complete, does not need you, does not buckle, and will not leave. Ask whether the shapes are a tool you use or a place you go to be safe. Probably both, at different times. The one worth catching is the second, and it is the harder one to see from the inside.
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Video Mine

Angles that could carry an episode. Not scripts. Raw ore.

- **"The Prayer Book for People Who Cannot Pray."** The psalms as assistive technology. Lead with Psalm 88 to establish that resolution is not required. The hook is that the most religious book in the Bible is written for people whose religion is not working.
 - **"You Become What You Look At."** Psalm 115:8 as mimetic law. Bridge to Girard's model without ever saying his name. Ends on Colossians 3:5, greed is idolatry.
 - **"Paul Had the Same Problem."** Romans 7 read as a case presentation. The wretched man is not a metaphor and not rhetorical. Ends on 8:1 with no comment.
 - **"The Verse Where Paul Refuses To Be Your Hero."** 1 Corinthians 11:1. Why every model becomes a rival, and the one structural exception.
 - **"Asaph Envied People and Said So in Church."** Psalm 73 as the most honest text in the canon. The sanctuary is the hinge, not the argument.
 - **"Paul's Mirror Was Made of Bronze."** The whole video is one correction. Everyone reads 1 Corinthians 13:12 as a modern mirror and hears "you only see yourself." Paul's mirror is a murky sheet of metal you look *through*, and the word he uses is *enigma*. Open with the object in your hand. The payoff is Numbers 12:8, where the phrase comes from, and the fact that he is handing Moses' privilege to everyone. Strong episode. The correction is the hook and almost nobody makes it.
 - **"The Refining Is the Looking."** The silversmith story, honestly labelled as a story, then 2 Corinthians 3:18 as the real claim. You are not polished so he can admire himself in you. You are changed by looking at him. Pairs with Psalm 115:8 as the same law inverted. Could be the strongest thing in this document.
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Progress Log

Add a dated line each pass. Do not delete old entries, even wrong ones.
The wrongness is the measurement.

Date	Pass	What I saw this time	What still confuses me
2026-07-17	0	Document created. Nothing read cold yet.	Everything, correctly.

Footnotes

Number your gutter notes and land them here so you can see the shape of your own understanding over time.

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.
- 4.
- 5.